



Incident handler's journal

Date: 6 October 2026	Entry: 1
Description	Investigated a simulated alert showing repeated failed logins followed by a successful sign-in. This exercise focused on the Detection and Analysis phase by building a timeline, identifying the affected account, and recommending containment steps based on available evidence.
Tool(s) used	Sample authentication logs and a simulated security alert dashboard.
The 5 W's	• Who: An unidentified actor generated the suspicious login attempts. The available logs do not establish the actor's real identity. • What: Multiple failed authentication attempts were followed by a successful login, suggesting a possible account compromise. • When: The activity occurred during a short period between 02:10 and 02:18 in the simulated log timeline. • Where: The activity targeted an organization's remote login portal and a user account. • Why: The activity may have resulted from password guessing or reused credentials. Further investigation would be necessary to confirm the root cause.
Additional notes	Preserve the authentication logs, verify the activity with the account owner, reset the password if compromise is confirmed, revoke suspicious sessions, and enable multifactor authentication (MFA). Escalate the incident according to the organization's response procedures.

Date: 7 October 2026	Entry: 2
Description	Reviewed a simulated phishing report involving a message that imitated a trusted service and directed a recipient to a credential-harvesting page. The activity covered Detection and Analysis and initial Containment, Eradication, and Recovery recommendations.
Tool(s) used	Sample email headers and a safe URL-inspection exercise.
The 5 W's	• Who: The sender's identity was unverified. The message used a display name or domain resembling a trusted organization. • What: The email encouraged the recipient to click a suspicious link and enter account credentials on a lookalike sign-in page. • When: The message was investigated after delivery and before any credential submission was confirmed in the simulated scenario. • Where: The message appeared in the recipient's email inbox and linked to a suspicious external website. • Why: The likely goal was to use social engineering to obtain credentials. Additional evidence would be needed to confirm the sender's identity and intent.
Additional notes	Preserve the email and its headers, report and quarantine the message, and block confirmed malicious indicators according to organizational procedures. If a recipient entered credentials, reset the affected password and review active sessions. Share a reminder about checking sender addresses and links before clicking.

Date: 8 October 2026	Entry: 3
Description	Practiced using Wireshark in a controlled lab to inspect a packet capture, identify endpoints and protocols, and look for unusual connection patterns. This supports Preparation and Detection and Analysis by developing network-analysis skills before real incidents.
Tool(s) used	Opened a provided packet capture file in Wireshark for analysis in a controlled environment. Applied display filters, such as <code>dns</code> or <code>ip.addr == <address></code>, to narrow the packets displayed. Reviewed timestamps, source and destination IP addresses, protocols, and DNS activity to identify patterns requiring further investigation. Recorded relevant packet details and summarized the findings so another analyst could review the evidence.
The 5 W's	Not applicable as a separate incident investigation; this entry documents a tool-focused lab exercise.
Additional notes	Packet analysis helps analysts understand network communications and investigate suspicious connections. Only capture or examine traffic when authorized, preserve relevant evidence, and verify suspicious findings using additional data sources.

Date:	Entry:
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9 October 2026	4
Description	Used VirusTotal as an initial reputation-checking resource for a practice domain or file hash. This supported Preparation and Detection and Analysis by demonstrating how threat intelligence can assist triage while requiring independent validation of the results.
Tool(s) used	• Checked a practice domain, public URL, or known sample file hash to review available security detections. • Examined the reported detection results and vendor labels as indicators rather than conclusive proof that an item was malicious. • Compared the results with other evidence, such as email headers, DNS records, or security logs, before drawing conclusions. • Documented the indicator checked, the date of the lookup, the key findings, and any follow-up needed.
The 5 W's	Not applicable as a separate incident investigation; this entry records a threat-intelligence tool exercise.
Additional notes	Reputation services can support an investigation, but detection results may be incomplete or incorrect. Do not upload confidential files or sensitive organizational data to a public analysis service without authorization. Correlate findings with other evidence before recommending a response.

Reflections/Notes: